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Educating for Equitable and Inclusive AI

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What we normally mean by “AI education”

Teach users to prompt

Training people to use AI tools

Teach engineers to code

Training more people to build AI

Both aim to close the skills gap. Both prepare people to ***fit*** a technology designed by a small nu mber of firms, under a narrow set of values.

The question today

Not: how should AI be used in education?

But: what kind of education is needed for AI to reduce, rather than rep roduce, inequality?

My answer: an education for equitable AI

Critical

rather than merely instrumental

Collective

rather than only individual

Plural

in its knowledges

Anchored in agency

of those most affected by AI

Internationally: an education system where no one is left behind, and everyone has a role to play in developing and deploying AI

Four issues today

01

How today's AI education reproduces inequality

02

Five shifts to change education

03

Who needs to learn what

04

The institutions we need

Three channels that reproduce inequality

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1 How we train the builders

A problem-solving mindset: performance, efficiency, scale. Ethics, if taught at all, is an add-on.

2 What we teach everyone else

“AI literacy” as using tools productively and safely: people as individual users of products.

3 Where expertise is concentrated

A handful of universities, firms and countries. Talent flows South to North, public to private.

Rarely asked

Works for whom?
At whose expense?
Should it exist at all?

Rarely asked

Who owns data and compute?
How is value distributed?

The result

Those most exposed to AI’s harms have the least voice.

Five educational shifts

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	FROM		TO
1	Tool literacy	→	**Political-economy literacy**
2	Individual competence	→	**Collective capacity**
3	A single knowledge tradition	→	**Plural knowledges**
4	Abstract ethics	→	**Situated harms and rights**
5	Adaptation	→	**Agency** *most important*

Shift 1 · Political-economy literacy

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AI is a production system, not just a product. *Behind a single chatbot answer sit…*

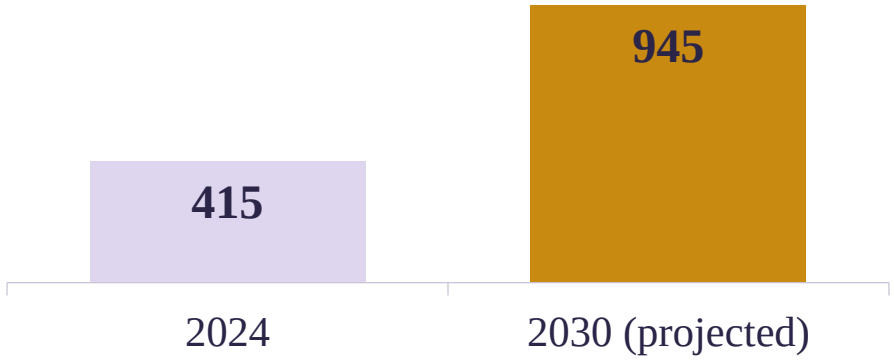
Minerals mined for chips → Chips and compute → Data centres: energy and water → Low-paid data annotators → One chatbot answer

Ownership of data, compute and models is concentrated

Questions political economy asks

- Who captures the value?
- Who bears the costs, including environmental ones?
- What alternatives could distribute them differently?

Data-centre electricity use (TWh)



Source: IEA (2025), Energy and AI: data centres used ~415 TWh in 2024 (~1.5% of global electricity), set to more than double to ~945 TWh by 2030.

Shifts 2 and 3 · Collective and plural

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SHIFT 2

From individual competence to collective capacity

Equality is a collective achievement

- Unions negotiating algorithmic management
- Teachers' associations assessing edtech
- Cooperatives building shared data infrastructure
- Communities auditing local deployments

SHIFT 3

From a single knowledge tradition to plural knowledges

Changing which problems are worth solving

- Feminist and decolonial science studies
- Indigenous data sovereignty
- Disability studies
- Non-Western philosophies of personhood

Shift 4 · Situated harms and rights

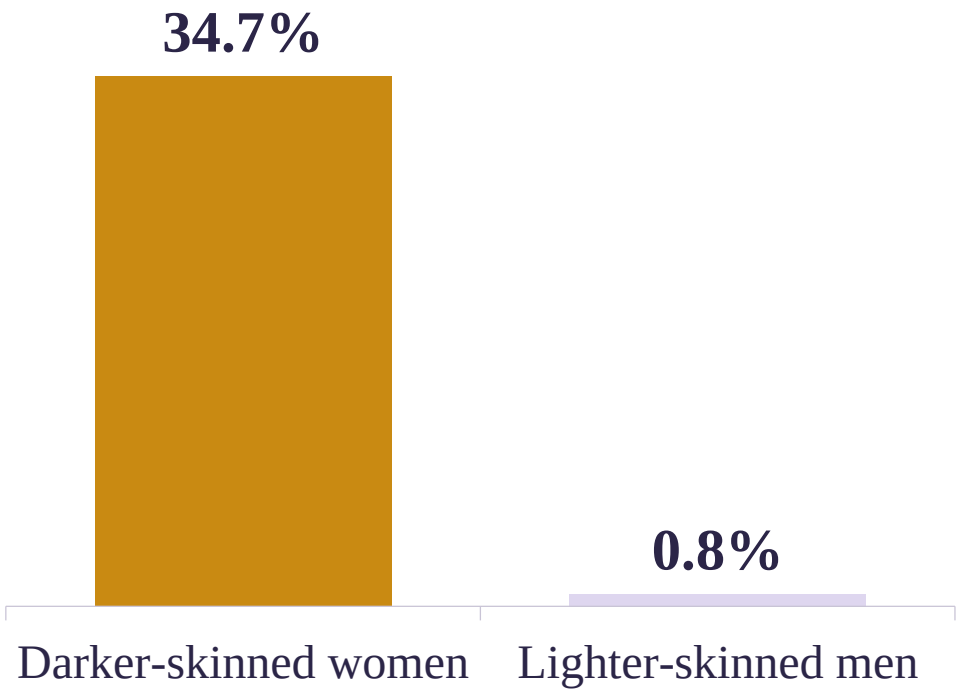
Recognise concrete harms

- Whose face goes unrecognised
- Whose accent is flagged as cheating
- Whose gaze is read as disengagement

Connect harms to enforceable rights and the institutions that uphold them

"Ethics without rights is just a wish."

A situated harm: maximum error rates of commercial gender classifiers



Source: Buolamwini & Gebru (2018), "Gender Shades", Proceedings of Machine Learning Research 81.

Shift 5 · From adaptation to agency

Equip people not only to cope with AI, but to govern it

Govern

Take part in impact assessments, procu rement and regulation

Refuse

Say no to harmful deployments

Build

Create alternatives

Critical questions to teach

1. What is being done in the name of AI?
2. To whom?
3. Who benefits?
4. How can democratic oversight be ex erted?

Emily Bender, as cited by Neil Selwyn

Who needs to learn what

Developers and engineers	Social science of technology, participatory design, and when not to build: core, not elective
Policymakers	AI markets, procurement and distributional impact; how to resist v endor hype
Teachers	Evaluate edtech critically, protect students' data rights, build agenc y not dependence
Workers and citizens	Their rights, collective bargaining over AI, local alternatives via u nions, co-ops and the SSE
Global South institutions	Build and govern AI on their own terms, in their own languages, th rough South-South exchange

Two priorities deserve emphasis

DEVELOPERS

Highest leverage

Upstream design choices → **Hard to reverse**

Design choices made upstream are hard to undo downstream.

Make social analysis a core engineering competence

GLOBAL SOUTH

Not about “catching up”

Southern institutions set their own research agendas and define the problems AI should address.

Otherwise: a workforce for data labelling and outsourced development, while value and decisions stay elsewhere

Education is inseparable from AI sovereignty and fair international collaboration

Five conditions to realise the shifts

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Education for equitable AI

Keep
AI education public

Fund
inter-disciplinary teaching

Mobilise
civil society and the SSE

Rebalance
international collaboration

Bring
affected people into governance

Built on the five shifts: critical, collective, plural, rights-based, agency-centred

Prepare people to shape AI

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THE DOMINANT MODEL

Prepares people for AI

How can people fit the technology?

AN EDUCATION FOR EQUALITY

Prepares people to shape AI

So that the technology fits them

Critical | **Collective** | **Plural** | **Public** | **Participatory**

Not rejecting AI, but making different use of AI for more just outcomes: which depends on people, everywhere, who understand how AI is made, who benefits, and how it could be otherwise.

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Thank you

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